

- RAG Learning

1.3 The Prime Minister and Cabinet

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 1 (Government and Politics of the UK)

The Prime Minister is the head of the UK government; the cabinet is the committee of senior ministers that is formally its key decision-making body. Neither office is defined by statute. Both rest almost entirely on **convention**, which is why the relationship between them has shifted so much between premierships without any change in the law.

The central exam question for this topic is not "what powers does the Prime Minister have?" — those are broadly fixed. It is **why the same set of powers produces a dominant Prime Minister in one period and a powerless one in another**. Almost every 25-mark question on 3.1.1.3 is a version of that question.

1. The Prime Minister

Origins and status

The office developed by convention from the eighteenth century. The Prime Minister is the person able to command the confidence of the House of Commons — in practice, the leader of the largest party after a general election. The monarch formally appoints them, but has no real discretion where one party has a majority.

Crucially, the Prime Minister is **not directly elected**. They hold office because their party made them leader and because their party holds a Commons majority. Both of those can be withdrawn, and neither requires a general election. This is the single most important structural fact about the office.

Powers of the Prime Minister

Power	What it means	Limit on it
Patronage	Appoints, promotes, reshuffles and dismisses ministers; recommends peerages and honours	Must balance party factions; dangerous figures are often safer inside the government than outside it
Chairing cabinet	Sets the agenda, decides what is discussed and for how long, and sums up the outcome	Cabinet's collective consent is what sustains the premiership; withdrawal of support is fatal
Party leadership	Commands the whips and the parliamentary party; controls the legislative programme	Both main parties can remove a leader at any time
Royal prerogative	Deploys the armed forces, makes treaties, makes senior appointments; since the 2022 repeal of the Fixed-term Parliaments Act, requests an early general election	Narrowed by convention (Commons consultation before military action since 2003) and by the courts (Miller I and Miller II)
National leadership	Public face of the government at home and abroad; sets the political agenda through the media	Depends entirely on personal standing and poll ratings

Sources of support: the Prime Minister's Office and Cabinet Office

- **Prime Minister's Office** — the PM's personal staff: policy advisers, press and communications, political secretaries. Has grown substantially since the 1990s.
- **Cabinet Office** — coordinates policy across departments, services cabinet and its committees, and is headed by the Cabinet Secretary, the most senior civil servant.
- **Special advisers (SpAds)** — politically appointed, exempt from civil service impartiality requirements, and loyal personally to the minister who appointed them. Their growth is frequently cited as evidence of a more personalised style of government.

Exam Tip: Don't list these as though they are powers. They are *resources*. The examinable point is that the expansion of the centre has given Number 10 an independent policy and communications capacity it did not have in 1945 — which is one of the strongest pieces of evidence for the presidentialisation argument.

2. The Cabinet

Composition and function

Around 20–25 senior ministers, almost all heading a government department, meeting weekly. Formally, cabinet is where government policy is agreed. In practice its functions are now better described as:

- **Ratifying** decisions largely settled elsewhere — in bilateral meetings, cabinet committees or informal groups
- **Coordinating** across departments and resolving disputes that officials could not settle
- **Legitimising** policy by binding every minister to it through collective responsibility
- **Managing** the party and the parliamentary timetable

Cabinet committees

Most detailed policy work happens in cabinet committees — smaller groups of ministers with delegated authority over a policy area. The Prime Minister decides which committees exist, what they cover and who sits on them, which is a significant and under-appreciated instrument of control.

3. Collective and individual ministerial responsibility

Collective ministerial responsibility: all members of the government are bound by decisions taken collectively. They must publicly support government policy whatever their

private view, cabinet discussions remain confidential, and a minister who cannot support a decision is expected to resign in order to criticise it.

Suspensions. The convention has occasionally been suspended where an issue cut across party lines so sharply that enforcing unity would have split the government — notably during the 1975 and 2016 EU referendums, when ministers were free to campaign on either side.

Erosion. Repeated leaks, briefing against colleagues and public disagreement have weakened the unity the convention is meant to project, even though the formal rule is unchanged.

Individual ministerial responsibility: ministers are personally accountable to Parliament for their own conduct and for the policies and administration of their department.

This has weakened considerably. Three reasons matter for the exam:

1. **The policy/operational distinction** — since the Next Steps executive agencies were created from 1988, ministers have distinguished policy failures, for which they accept responsibility, from operational ones, which they attribute to agency chief executives or officials.
2. **Departmental scale** — it is widely accepted that a minister cannot know of every failing in a very large department, which makes resignation look disproportionate rather than principled.
3. **Prime ministerial protection** — whether a minister survives now depends heavily on whether the Prime Minister will spend political capital defending them, so outcomes track factional strength rather than the gravity of the failure.

The convention retains real force over **personal conduct** and over **misleading Parliament**, where resignations remain relatively common.

4. What determines the balance between PM and cabinet?

This is the heart of the topic. The formal powers are constant; the political context is not.

Factor	Strengthens the PM	Strengthens cabinet / weakens the PM

Size of Commons majority	Large majority — rebels can be ignored (Blair 1997, Johnson 2019)	Small or no majority — factions gain veto power (May after 2017)
Party unity	United party behind the leader	Factionalised party (Major and the Maastricht rebels)
Personal authority and polls	Reputation for winning elections	Poor polling; a leader seen as an electoral liability
Calibre of colleagues	Cabinet of loyalists with no independent base	Senior rivals with their own following (Blair–Brown)
Events and the economy	Crisis handled well (Falklands, 1982)	Crisis handled badly (ERM 1992; the 2022 mini-budget)
Time in office	The honeymoon period	Authority typically erodes over a long premiership

Exam Tip: The best answers use **paired examples** to show the same power producing opposite results. Thatcher's patronage let her remake the cabinet in her image through the 1980s — and it was that same cabinet, canvassed individually in 1990, that ended her premiership. The power did not change; her political position did.

5. The presidentialisation debate

The claim, associated with Michael Foley's work on the "British presidency", is that the premiership has taken on characteristics of a presidential executive.

Evidence for

- **Personalised mandates** — campaigns fought around leaders, with televised debates since 2010 encouraging voters to treat the choice as one between individuals.
- **Bilateralism and "sofa government"** — policy settled with the relevant minister or in small ad hoc groups, with cabinet presented with decisions to ratify. The Butler Review criticised this in

relation to the Iraq war.

- **Growth of the centre** — expansion of the PM's Office, the Cabinet Office and special advisers gives Number 10 a capacity resembling a presidential executive office.
- **Spatial leadership** — Prime Ministers increasingly present themselves as standing above their party.
- **Foreign and security policy** — conducted largely through the prerogative, reinforcing a head-of-state style.

Evidence against

- **Tenure is conditional** — this is the decisive objection. A Prime Minister holds office only while commanding party and cabinet support, and can be removed within days. Thatcher, May, Johnson and Truss all left office without losing a general election. No president faces this.
- **No veto and no separate mandate** — the PM has no power to block legislation and no personal electoral mandate independent of the Commons.
- **Dependence on the majority** — a PM with a small majority may be weaker than almost any president, as May's record-breaking Commons defeats showed.
- **Cabinet still binds** — more than fifty resignations from the government in two days ended Johnson's premiership in 2022.

Exam Tip: A strong conclusion does not simply pick a side. The most defensible position is that the presidential analogy captures the *style* of modern leadership accurately but misdescribes its *security*: UK Prime Ministers look more presidential than ever in how they campaign and communicate, while remaining far more easily removed than any president.

Key terms

Term	Definition
Royal prerogative	Residual Crown powers exercised in practice by ministers, requiring no statutory authority

Patronage	The power to appoint, promote and dismiss ministers, and to recommend honours
Collective responsibility	The convention binding all ministers to support government decisions publicly or resign
Individual responsibility	The convention that ministers are accountable to Parliament for their own conduct and their department
Core executive	Model treating power as distributed across a network of interdependent actors — PM, cabinet, advisers, senior officials and the Treasury — rather than held by any one of them
Presidentialisation	The thesis that the premiership has acquired a personalised, media-focused leadership style resembling a presidential executive
Sofa government	Informal decision-making in small groups outside the full cabinet, associated with Blair

Essential examples

- **Thatcher, 1990** — removed after canvassing cabinet individually: cabinet support as the ultimate constraint.
- **Blair–Brown** — Treasury control of departmental allocations creating a rival power centre.
- **Butler Review, 2004** — criticism of informal decision-making before the Iraq war.
- **May, 2017–19** — largest Commons defeat in modern history; cabinet repeatedly forcing changes to Brexit policy.
- **Johnson, 2022** — more than fifty government resignations in two days.
- **Truss, 2022** — market reaction to the mini-budget destroying authority in under seven weeks.
- **2016 referendum** — collective responsibility formally suspended.